

Tiny Bodies, Big Brains — Module 08: Planning — Think About It

Part A: Family Discussion Questions

1. What would happen if you put your shoes on BEFORE your socks? (The order matters in planning!).
2. Why is a bedtime routine helpful? (Your brain and body know what to expect — less stress, better sleep).
3. Can a baby plan ahead? (Not much — their brain is still building the planning system).
4. What is "Executive Function"? (The brain's control center — it helps you focus, wait, and switch tasks).
5. Why is it hard to wait for something you really want? (Inhibitory control is tough! Your brain is still practicing).
6. What happens when you skip a step in a recipe? (Surprise! The brain expected one thing and got another).
7. How many steps can you hold in your head at once? (Most people can hold about 3-5 steps).
8. What is the longest-term plan you have ever made? (A birthday party? A school project? A vacation?).
9. Why do routines change as you grow up? (Your brain can handle more complexity and more steps).
10. What is Plan B? Why is it important to have one?

Part B: Hands-On Activities and Reflection

1. Create a "Picture Schedule" for your bedtime routine. Draw each step: bath, pajamas, teeth, story, lights out. Follow it tonight. Did it make bedtime smoother?
2. Plan a simple snack together: Write the steps FIRST, then follow them. (1. Wash hands. 2. Get crackers. 3. Spread peanut butter. 4. Add raisins. 5. Eat!). How did planning first help?

3. Play "Simon Says" — this game tests executive function! You must listen, remember the rule ("only do it if I say Simon Says"), and control your actions. How many rounds can you last?
4. Build a structure with blocks or Legos by following a plan. Then build one WITHOUT a plan. Which turned out better? Which was more fun?
5. Make a "Morning Countdown" poster. List everything that needs to happen before leaving the house and the time each step takes. Does having a plan reduce morning rush?
6. Do the "Marshmallow Test" (family-friendly version): Put a treat in front of you. Can you wait 5 minutes before eating it? What strategies help you wait? (Look away, sing a song, think of something else).
7. Plan a mini treasure hunt for a family member: Write three clues that lead to a surprise. Planning for someone else requires imagining what THEY will think and do.
8. Together, plan one special activity for next month. Write it on the calendar. List what you need to prepare. Check off items as you get ready. Planning turns wishes into reality!
9. Play "What Comes Next?": Start a pattern (clap-clap-stomp, clap-clap-stomp). Can your family figure out the plan and join in? Pattern recognition is the beginning of planning.
10. At bedtime, think about three things you want to do tomorrow. Put them in order (first, next, last). You just made a plan! Sleep tight — your brain will prepare for it while you rest.